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Sol Yaged

Clarinetist Sol Yaged was born on December 8, 1922 in New York City. He studied classical clarinet with Simeon Bellison of the New York Philharmonic but chose to enter the popular world of swing music in his early twenties. An unabashed admirer of Benny Goodman, he served as technical advisor in the 1956 film "The Benny Goodman Story" teaching Steve Allen to effectively mimic the Goodman mannerism. Sol worked steadily in the numerous jazz clubs of New York City with a variety of bands, eventually taking the role of organizing and leading his own small groups. Well into his seventh decade of performing, he continues to keep swing alive with his clarinet and outgoing personality.

Sol was interviewed in New York City on January 29, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming —

SY: My name is Sol Yaged.

MR: Sol Yaged — he's killing me already. We are at one of Sol's favorite hotels, the Mayflower in Manhattan.

SY: I know the hotel very well, I spent a week here one night. Don't use that Tim.

MR: I'm wondering if you could have had a dual career as a comedian, or do you work it in in what you do?

SY: Well I played in shows with people like Jackie Mason, Henny Youngman, Buddy Hackett, Don Rickles. I played many, many years ago up in the Catskills with George Burns, Dean Martin, Jerry Lewis, I did shows with them. So all these things rub off. I did a show a few weeks ago with Alan King at the Friar's Club. You know Jackie Mason Tim? Tim? You changed your name?

TH: You've got to ignore me here. You talk to him.

SY: You know who Jackie Mason is?

MR: Sure do.

SY: I had lunch with him at the Friar's Club.

MR: Yeah?

SY: And he picked up the check.

MR: No kidding.

SY: Yeah, then he handed it to me.

MR: Born and raised in Brooklyn I see.

SY: That's right.

MR: That's right. My goodness.

SY: Where are you from originally?

MR: I'm from Rochester.

SY: Then you probably remember a place I worked 35 years ago, Doug Duke's.

MR: Doug Duke's. I was born about six blocks from that.

SY: Oh the River Street? River Road?

MR: It was Lake Avenue.

SY: Lake. Thank you for correcting me. I stand to be corrected. I don't know why I said River. Lake Avenue. That's 35 years ago I worked for Doug Duke's.

MR: I saw Al Cohn there too.

SY: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. How about that?

SY: That's right. Lake Avenue. Thank you for correcting me.

MR: Well listen, I've been reading something about you, a number of things. In 1977, I don't know where this came from, but you were named the City's busiest musician.

SY: I still am.

MR: And I'm looking at this stuff you sent me. How do you do it? Six nights a week?

SY: I do a double header Tim, every Sunday. I play Sunday brunch at a place called Tony McGregor's from 12-5, and then I go to a place called Danny's Sea Palace from 7-11. I enjoy it. It doesn't bother me.

MR: That's great. When you were 13 years old — I don't know why I picked 13 — did you have aspirations to be a full time musician at that age?

SY: Well when I heard Benny Goodman on the radio, I was about 13 years old then you're right — what made you pick that year out?

MR: Oh, I have my sources.

SY: Okay. I was born in 1922. If I was born in 1922, Monk, and I heard Benny Goodman on the radio in 1934, how old was I?

MR: 14.

SY: Okay then I was 14. I heard him do a radio broadcast with his band. And it was an unbelievable band. They were so hot I still get goose pimples talking about this band 60 years ago, 65 years ago. I says I've got to buy the clarinet. I didn't know if I was going to be a professional or what. Thank God that's all I've been doing all my life. I've been very fortunate. I wish my wife was here. I just lost my wife a few years ago. We were married for 51 glorious years. I'll show you pictures of her later. She was my wife, my manager, my agent. And not for her I wouldn't be here talking to you today my dear friend. She helped me every way and any way. She used to say to me Tim, my wife, "look, you play

the clarinet, I'll take care of the business." And she did. That's why I'm living where I'm living now on 56th Street and Lexington Avenue for the past 25, 27 years. I'll show you pictures of my wife later if you don't mind, when she was 15 years old when I met her. 15. We got married my dear friend when she was 16, and we had our first child when my wife was 17 years old. Had I listened to her 30 years ago I would have been better off but I thought I knew all the answers. I thought I was going to be a star you know, stardom. A woman told me last night, she said to me last night Tim, are you listening to me, she says, "Sol, you're the world's greatest clarinet player." I says, "How come?" She came up to me, she was crying, she says, "Mr. Yaged you're the world's greatest clarinet player." I said, "how come?" She says, "Everybody else is dead." And then she says, I belong in Hollywood." She says, "The walk will do you good." And you know what else she says to me, Monk? She says, "I belong on the stage." She says, "It leaves in five minutes."

MR: Yes indeed. I see you've worked with —

SY: Good song "Yes Indeed." Sy Oliver wrote that.

MR: Look, "don't be that way," okay?

[audio interlude, Sol plays "Don't Be That Way"]

MR: Thank you.

SY: My pleasure.

MR: Thank you very much.

SY: That's a different mouthpiece than I've been using for 30 years. I don't know how the hell it's working but it's working.

MR: Well if you can play soft on it like that that's a good sign.

SY: Thank you sir. By the way that was Benny Goodman's opening song.

MR: I know it was.

SY: Right. Carnegie Hall. He always played that, wherever he played. It never failed. He had to play that. People asked for it, and he always had to close his show with "Sing Sing Sing." Can you imagine playing that 5, 6, 7, 8 times a day and night? He played it at the Paramount Theater. And one time, I'll never forget, Monk, he was playing at the Paramount Theater in the Pennsylvania Hotel. He was doing a radio broadcast called the Camel Caravan, he was recording, I don't know when he had time. Gene Krupa told me he had six sets of drums in the city, and Lionel Hampton told me he had six sets of vibraphones, one at the Pennsylvania, one at the recording studio, one at the radio station, one at the Paramount Hotel, he had his drums there, a set of drums there. So it was the Pennsylvania Hotel, the Paramount Theater, CBS right here on 53rd street, you know where I'm talking about Monk? That's where I saw Benny Goodman for the first time, coming out of the stage door, in I think it was 1937. I couldn't believe how tall he was.

MR: You couldn't believe how tall he was?

SY: Yeah.

MR: Yeah he didn't seem like a tall person.

SY: He was six foot two, oh yeah. And I still love to play. I never get bored playing. If I have to play a song four or five times a night it doesn't bother me, I'll play it at different tempos or I'll play it in a different key. I know how to get around little things like that. If I have to play a song like "As Time Goes By," I can play it like —[Sol plays] — or if I have to play it again I'll play it — [Sol plays] — you know to give it a little twist. Like with Tony Bennett "San Francisco," he has to sing that every show for the past 50 years. So imagine Benny Goodman playing "Don't Be That Way" and "Sing Sing Sing," it was unbelievable.

MR: Right. The clarinet seems to be one of the harder instruments to play.

SY: Very difficult.

MR: Were you put off by that at first when you were a kid?

SY: It made me persevere more, Monk, because I enjoy a little bit of a — what's the word I'm thinking of.

MR: Challenge?

SY: That's a good word. Thank you for that word. A bit of a challenge. I didn't want to use the word battle. Yeah it was a bit of a challenge. And when I couldn't get a piece of music together I worked on it note by note my dear friend, not piece by piece or bar by bar, but note by note I worked on it. Like [Sol plays] — You know that piece?

MR: I do not know that piece.

SY: That's Mozart. Now that was in E flat. Now I'm going to play it in the key originally written, in five sharps. [Sol plays]. What's the name of this, Monk? [Sol plays].

MR: That's Mozart too.

SY: I've been playing that for 60 years until I get it right.

MR: Did your clarinet teachers, when you were growing up, appreciate swing music? I mean because you obviously had a good classical teacher.

SY: The teacher I went to, I don't know if you saw it in the article I gave you, Monk, his name was Simeon Bellison. He played clarinet with the New York Philharmonic for 40 years. Number one, if he knew you played saxophone, which I did not play saxophone, he wouldn't teach you. If he knew you played jazz he wouldn't teach you. The only one he accepted, because he was a big, big name, was Benny Goodman. And I was studying with Simeon Bellison at the same time Benny Goodman was going to him in 1946. He lived on Walton Avenue in the Bronx on 161st Street. I used to travel from Brooklyn to the Bronx on a train, a two hour ride, to take a lesson for one hour, and a two hour ride to

go home. And I used to practice my clarinet on the train. I would practice my lesson, Monk, so that I won't make any mistakes, on the train going up there. And then I would practice my lesson going home, so I won't forget what my teacher taught me, Simeon Bellison. He was one of the greatest authorities on the clarinet. The greatest. He was a professor. He came from Russia, Moscow, and to show you how great he was, he was nine years old when he played with the Moscow Symphony Orchestra. Is that unbelievable? It's in his life story. Nine years old. He was just phenomenal. He made his own reeds and as I said, if he knew you played jazz he says I can't teach you. He wanted everyone to be a symphony clarinetist.

MR: I see. Well you had an opportunity to work with the Buffalo Philharmonic?

SY: No I never played but I was offered the position with them. I never played. But I took an audition, and that sounds very familiar. That rhymes — position and audition. Anyhow I took an audition with a man called — let me see if I remember his name — Steinberg. He was a conductor of the Buffalo Symphony Orchestra. I'm pretty sure that was his name, [William] Steinberg. And they offered me the job, like $75, but we had to move to Buffalo. And my wife, who was my manager and agent, she said let's stay in New York. And right after that I got myself a steady job at Jimmy Ryan's on 52nd Street.

MR: Did you work — I'm sorry, you were in the service, right? In the Army?

SY: Yes I was in the service for two years.

MR: Did you get to play while you were there?

SY: Well luckily, again for my wife, Monk, originally I was in an outfit called the 297th Engineer Combat Battalion. I don't know if you know what that is. They are the infantry but they build bridges. Before the regular infantry came along, we used to build a bridge called the Bailey Bridge. So here is Sol Yaged marching with the 297th Engineer Combat Battalion with a gun in one hand, a shovel in the other hand, and I had my clarinet case with me under my arm. Wherever I went I took it with me. Because when we took a break for 15, 20 minutes, I'd take out my clarinet and practice a little bit. After being with the outfit for about 4-5 months we were going to be shipped out, my wife got me a transfer to the Air Force Band here in Fort Dix, New Jersey. And I was very fortunate to be with the 395th Army Air Force Band. And there was 30 musicians in that band, and believe it or not, ironically, 28 were from Providence, Rhode Island. They all signed up together and they all formed this band, the Army Air Force Band in Ft. Dix, New Jersey. A lot of great musicians were with them.

MR: So you were able to do that instead of get shipped overseas?

SY: That's right. We were all sent overseas just the day before I was transferred. In other words, after I was transferred to the Army Air Force Band at Ft. Dix, they went right

overseas. We were at the Port of Embarkation, Monk, at Camp Kilmer, New Jersey. I'll never forget that. And we knew we were going to go overseas in a matter of a day or two. And my wife went to the Lieutenant, to speak to him on my behalf. His name was Lieutenant Danzinger. Look how I remember that name, 50 years ago. D-A-N-Z-I-N-G-E-R. Lieutenant Danzinger. But before he was able to give me the transfer, Monk, my wife had to go to see the major of that battalion. And his name was Major Fox. She spoke to him. My wife was pregnant at that time and she went to speak to him that she wanted me near home and that I was a musician, a clarinetist, and I would do more in the morale of playing with the band. And she got me with the band exactly one day before they were shipped out. It was unbelievable.

MR: Well the music that you were attracted to and you began to play, did you and the rest of the players think of it as — I'm trying to figure out how to say this — was it the popular music of the day or did you think of it as you were playing something from the past?

SY: You're talking about when I started to play?

MR: Like at Jimmy Ryan's.

SY: Yeah. That was the popular music of the day, sure. I didn't know anything about the Original Dixieland Jazz Band at that time, man I just thought that this is the music. Dixieland music and swing music, that was the music of the day.

MR: You played mostly for dancing?

SY: No it was jazz. If anybody wanted to get up to dance they wouldn't prevent them Monk, but it was mostly listening at Jimmy Ryan's. I went in there for two weeks and I stayed there for one year. And I had a great drummer with me if you don't mind me mentioning his name — I don't think he's around today — he was from Chicago, his name was Danny Alvin. Great drummer, sensational. And I had Hank Duncan on piano. And we had a trio. And we went in there for two weeks and we stayed for one year with this trio. And you know whose place I took?

MR: No.

SY: He became — he wasn't my friend anymore — I took Mezzrow, Mezzrow's place. He was playing there and they engaged me in place of him. Milton Mezzrow. And he never spoke to me after that.

MR: What were the hours like on a job like that?

SY: I think it was about five hours at that time. Something like nine to two.

MR: Can you recall what you made for each person in the band back then?

SY: I do. What made you ask me that question?

MR: I think it's interesting to see what—

SY: Okay. I made $50 a week. And I was working I think it was six nights a week. And I'm talking about the 40s, Monk, 1946, '47.

MR: Was that decent money?

SY: I don't know. I was able to exist with it.

MR: Did you ever have to do non-musical jobs to augment your income?

SY: No. I've been very fortunate. Thank you for asking that question. I've been very fortunate just to play the clarinet. And I'm one of the few guys that I can think of that didn't have to make a living by playing saxophone, clarinet and flute. I just wanted to be a specialist on the clarinet. I wanted to play jazz, I wanted to play classical, I'm able to play Klezmer music. I've been just specialized on the clarinet. I brought you some pictures I'll show you later, taken of me at Jimmy Ryan's, and someone took them off the Internet. Wait 'til you see these pictures. I'm playing with Rex Stewart and a lot of other jazz musicians.

MR: Well the list of people you've been with is just unbelievable.

SY: Thank you, sir.

MR: Fletcher Henderson. What can you tell me about working with Fletcher?

SY: A very fine gentleman. A wonderful man, a wonderful pianist, and one of the highlights of my career because I knew about his music with Benny Goodman and he actually took me under his wing. He was very nice to me, and very warm and gracious to me. And every time I played with Fletcher Henderson I was thinking about the days that Benny Goodman was playing his music. "King Porter Stomp," "Wrapping it Up," "Stealing Apples," "Dear Old Southland." And when I played with him I felt like I was in my glory. He's a wonderful musician, wonderful.

MR: What about working with, you know I hear an awful lot of stories about Eddie Condon.

SY: I played with him occasionally, you know, I wasn't the number one clarinet player with him, I'll be very honest with you. The number one clarinetist was Pee Wee Russell. And then when Pee Wee Russell wasn't able to make it they used Tony Parenti, a wonderful Dixieland clarinetist from New Orleans. And then they used other musicians, a clarinet player that worked with him for a while was Peanuts Hucko, a wonderful clarinetist. But when they couldn't get these clarinetists that I mentioned then they came to me. I was like the low man on the totem pole. But whenever he called me, he called me. I worked at Eddie Condon's or I worked at Nick's in the Village. I worked there with Muggsy Spanier, with Pee Wee Russell there — I'm sorry, not Pee Wee Russell, with Pee Wee Irwin. I played there with Pee Wee Irwin's band and the trombone player at that time was Miff Mole.

MR: So you'd get a gig — when you went to a club to get a gig, did you have an actual band in mind or did you get the gig and then find the musicians to do it?

SY: I usually did what you just said, Monk, I got the gig and then I was able to pick up the musicians to do it. Like I was a sideman for a while at Nick's playing, as I said with Muggsy Spanier, Pee Wee Irwin, Jimmy McPartland, Miff Mole. And then they asked me to bring a band in, a Dixieland band. And I was the last band to play Nick's. I was proud to say I had the opportunity to go in there with my own band just before they went out of business, after being in business like 50 years. Then it became a place called Your Father's Moustache with banjos. They changed the whole policy. But I was the last band to go in there.

MR: Everybody that you would call would be expected to know a certain repertoire of tunes at that time?

SY: Oh yeah, sure. We had to know all the Dixieland songs like "Muskrat Ramble" and "That's a Plenty," and "Shimmy Shawabble," and "Panama" and "Sister Kate" and "Ballin' the Jack," and [Sol plays]. "Sweet Georgia Brown." Great piece of music, isn't it? That was written by my friend Maceo Pinkard, one of the great composers, Maceo Pinkard.

MR: Gee I hope he got royalties from the Harlem Globetrotters. You know, that became their theme song for all those years.

SY: Yeah right. They played a perfect tempo for it too.

MR: Yeah. Tell me about getting hooked up with Steve Allen.

SY: I was working at a place right before The Metropole, Monk, at a place called The Somerset Hotel on 47th Street off Seventh Avenue. The Metropole was on 48th and Seventh Avenue. I was there with a trio. And he used to come in every night to sit in with me, Steve Allen. This was before he had a show. He had just come to New York from Chicago, and we used to let him sit in with us all the time. And we became very good friends. I brought you some pictures of he and I together when we made the Benny Goodman picture. And I'm indebted to him quite a lot because he's done a lot for me. I've been on his show many a time. There's a picture of us being on the show the opening night of the Benny Goodman movie in Hollywood. I was on a show with Benny Goodman, Urbie Green, there's pictures of Stan Getz in the band, Buck Clayton. And he's been very kind to me, Steve Allen. And whenever he's in New York and he has to do a musical thing he always calls me. Great guy. And we got a lot of mileage out of "The Benny Goodman Story." It's still being shown today like years later.

MR: Right. Was he a good student?

SY: Excellent. The best. It was unbelievable. After a couple of lessons he was able to pick up the clarinet and play a blues. He was very astute. That's a good question you asked.

MR: Did Benny like the movie?

SY: Benny Goodman did not like the movie.

MR: It was Hollywoodized quite a bit I would imagine.

SY: Believe it or not, Monk, the picture did very well in Japan, Tokyo, Japan. I found out some time later after we made the movie that it stayed at one theater for over a year, that's how popular it was. It was very, very big in Japan, Tokyo. But they selected — Universal International Pictures selected Steve Allen and Benny Goodman gave his okay, but then I think he regretted it. And then Steve Allen selected me to be his coach, and Benny Goodman had to give his okay also.

MR: I see. What was Benny's personality like for you?

SY: What can I say? He was the king. He was the greatest. I don't care what he said or didn't say. I was happy to be in the same room with him. I used to go to all of his rehearsals, every one of his recording dates, Monk. And one day I came in late. He started at a certain time and I came in about 15, 20 minutes later because I was living in Brooklyn. He says, "Sol, you're late," like that he would say that to me. I felt very elated that he even said that to me. He was very nice, very gracious and warm to me. His wife Alice was a very fine woman. His brother-in-law, John Hammond, was very nice and warm to me.

MR: You and your wife handled all your affairs for all those years.

SY: Everything. She took care of everything. When we had to make the contract deal to go to Hollywood to make the movie she handled the business for me. We went out there for three months and we had a glorious time, glorious time. We used to go playing at night, Monk, we went to a jam session place every night in Glendale, California. I remember it as if it was yesterday. It was called The Melody Club. I used to go over there with Buck Clayton, with Urbie Green, Zoot Simms, Teddy Wilson went out there. We all went out there to sit in and play every night. Of course when you were making the movie you didn't get a chance to play very much because they were just waiting around. Remember the soundtrack was made before the movie was made. We made the soundtrack first. Then they put the sound in while they made the move.

MR: Yeah, so it was like, everybody was what they call lip syncing I guess, right?

SY: Correct, sure. Harry James, Ziggy Elman, everybody.

MR: You were in a movie yourself, weren't you, "Carnegie Hall?"

SY: Yeah, I was just another musician in the band, but it was a picture I made many years ago called "Carnegie Hall," right. How'd you know that?

MR: It's in one of the books.

SY: Thank you.

MR: Yeah. Tell me about working in this weird Metropole stage. That must have been kind of different to be all standing in a row.

SY: Right. Wall to wall jazz they called it. All in single file. We had one drummer at this end of the stage, Monk, we had another drummer at that end of the stage, we had two little upright pianos, they were like spinets, that's what they call them. And we had two sets of drums. It was a very strange thing but we all became acclimated to it. I know I did after being there for ten years. And I had a chance to play with the greatest of the greats: Gene Krupa, Buddy Rich, Cozy Cole, George Wettling, everyone was there, Lionel Hampton was there with his band, it was unbelievable.

MR: Tell me about working with your own group. How did the musical scene change for you over the years? I mean you've always managed to find work. But has there been a number of years, or a decade, where things have been tougher?

SY: Oh yeah, sure. Places I worked for years no longer existed, Monk. Restaurants out of business. Night clubs out of business. I mean like we're talking about Eddie Condon's, they folded up when they moved from the Village. They were in the Village, they moved Uptown to this certain hotel, 56th Street. It was after a couple of years or so and then they went out of business. Nick's went out of business. The Metropole went out of business. I was at The Gaslight Club for ten years with my quartet. Eventually they went out of business. I had a quartet which included Ray Nance on cornet with me.

MR: When did it become let's say acceptable to mix racially in the groups in New York City? Was there ever a problem for you?

SY: Not that I know of. I have been playing with black and white musicians all my life. I started, and I have pictures to prove it, I'll show them to you. One time I was on the stage with Jimmy Jones on piano and John Levy on bass. I'll show you the pictures. Tim are those gentlemen still outside? See if they're outside please. I never had a problem. I played on the stage with Sidney Bechet. I played on the stage with Wilbur DeParis, Sidney DeParis, J.C. Higginbotham. Didn't bother me. I know Benny Goodman had a difficult time when he first started in the 30's.

MR: Maybe you should make a call down to the front desk.

TH: What's their names?

SY: Their names are Sal and Arthur. Thank you Tim Hicks, thank you, sir.

MR: Did the guy near the elevator stop you?

SY: The security guard. And I gave him the information. He was very nice. In fact there were two security men there. You speak very nice by the way.

MR: Thank you.

SY: You have a very easy way of speaking. I like talking to you. See when Benny Goodman first started out with his band, 1935, he had Teddy Wilson with him and in 1936 Lionel Hampton. When he played certain places they didn't want — he said this is my band, take me as it is. He may have said this I don't know, but it's like saying what you see is what you get. I mean he didn't delete Lionel Hampton because he was black and he didn't let Cootie Williams out because he was black and he didn't leave Teddy Wilson out of the band because he was black. You know Benny Goodman at one time had an all-black rhythm section, and I was there. He had Big Sid Catlett on drums, he had John Simmons on bass, he had Charlie Christian on guitar, and he had Fletcher Henderson on piano. And I was there when they were playing at Frank Daily's Meadowbrook, Monk, in New Jersey. He had an all-black rhythm section. In fact I'll even tell you he had a black saxophone player with him at that time, Budd Johnson. So he had his share of black musicians at one time, a full array.

MR: That's a real shame Charlie Christian didn't last longer.

SY: I know.

MR: Did he cause quite a sensation with what he did?

SY: Oh yeah. He was a very young man when he passed away, very, very young. I think he was like 23, 24 years old.

MR: What do you feel about the state of jazz music today? Do you listen to any of the local radio stations and do you like what you hear?

SY: I particularly don't like what I hear anymore, Monk. I listened to a radio station all my life, for 50 years, WNEW, with a man called Martin Block. And he played the greatest of them all. He played Benny Goodman, Artie Shaw, Glenn Miller, Tommy Dorsey, Jan Savitt. He played the greatest bands of all. Glen Gray and the Casa Loma Band. You don't hear those records anymore. You don't hear that kind of music anymore.

MR: Well jazz in some sense became, in the 60's it became kind of political. It became sometimes angry. Do you think —

SY: Angry?

MR: Well when I think of fellas like Coltrane and that, it's like they were — it was very, very emotional.

SY: And a style like Miles Davis, you're right, very emotional. I didn't know John Coltrane. I knew Miles Davis when I was playing. When I was playing at Jimmy Ryan's he was across the street at a place called The Three Deuces. Miles Davis. But believe me in those days, and it was only the late 40s, they were angry and hostile too.

MR: I think it was 1946, quite a significant number of the big bands bit the dust.

SY: In the late 40s.

MR: Yeah. In your eyes, what was the reason for that?

SY: Probably, maybe because of the rock & roll coming in. Who knows? I remember a lot of places that the bands used to play in, Monk, were not around anymore. There was no music at the Waldorf Astoria anymore, where Benny Goodman played, Xavier Cugat played, and there was no Roosevelt Hotel anymore where they had music with Guy Lombardo. And there was no Paramount theater anymore where they had all the big bands. And there was no Strand Theater anymore, where they had the big bands. And there was no Capitol Theater anymore where they had the bands. It was unbelievable. Slowly by slowly all these places disappeared, Monk, where they had bands working seven days a week, seven nights a week. The Roseland Ballroom I remember seeing Fletcher Henderson there with his band. I saw Harry James there. I saw Tommy Dorsey at the Roseland. I saw my friend Jimmy Dorsey playing there. It just disappeared.

MR: Some of those fellas were able to find work in the studios in New York?

SY: Yeah. Right.

MR: But you, over the years, you've always been able to find —

SY: Yeah I was able to survive as you would say, Monk. Either I played with a trio or a quartet or a quintet, whatever it was. Now today thank God I'm playing seven nights a week, I'll give you the information if you want it. In some groups I play just clarinet and piano. In other groups I play with a trio. I play with a piano, bass and clarinet. In other groups I play with bass and guitar and myself. Then in another group I play with a rhythm section, drums, piano and bass. So I mean I'm able to maneuver. And as long as I'm playing my clarinet and I'm working, I'd rather play than stay home and hang out and do nothing. That's my whole life, music. Always has been.

MR: Has the musician's union been a help to you over the years?

SY: I don't know. I've been a member of the musician's union for over 60 years. Since 1939.

MR: Guess you're what they call a Life Member, right?

SY: Yeah, Life Member. Very good, Monk. Yeah. I've been a member since 1939. They're very nice, they take my dues every month. Yeah, they're all right. But there was a lot of great music at one time. I'll never forget the Lincoln Hotel on 46th, 47th Street and Eighth Avenue, I used to hear Artie Shaw's band, or some band, some great band. Charlie Barnet played that room, Jan Savitt played that room. It was owned by a woman called Marie Cramer her name was. She owned these two hotels, the Lincoln Hotel on Eighth Avenue and 47th Street, and then she owned the Edison Hotel on 46th Street off Broadway. But she used the "sweet" bands at that hotel. She used bands there like Blue Baron, Sammy Kaye and another band that became a hotel band later on, Henry Jerome and his orchestra. She used all the "sweet" bands at that hotel, the Edison Hotel, and the

Lincoln Hotel she used all the "hot" bands like Artie Shaw and Charlie Barnet and Jan Savitt. I'll never forget the first time, even though I adore Benny Goodman, where I first heard Artie Shaw play in person at the Lincoln Hotel, "Begin the Beguine." It was unbelievable. That sound was just unbelievable the way the band came in. Buddy Rich on drums, Tony Pastor on saxophone, a very exciting sound, very exciting. And the band was right on, Monk. He had a very tight band. I'll never forget when he was at the Strand Theater at the same time Benny Goodman was at the Paramount Theater. I was there. In fact it says that in the article I gave you, Monk. There was a big sign at the Paramount Theater with a picture of Benny Goodman with his clarinet, King of Swing. Then you walk up four, five, six blocks at the Strand Theater, a big sign, Artie Shaw, King of the Clarinet, with his picture. At the same time they both appeared, it was unbelievably exciting. Everybody was running back and forth. It was a very, very exciting two weeks.

MR: They were like rock stars of the day.

SY: Oh yeah.

MR: Yeah. Did they get along at all?

SY: They were sort of friends. I have a picture somewhere at home, I have a picture of Artie Shaw and Benny Goodman together. I think it was Benny Goodman going to see and hear Artie Shaw's band. I'm pretty sure it was that way.

MR: I wonder if anybody ever thought of trying to get them to record together.

SY: Impossible. They worked in the same band together on radio, I don't know if you know this, Monk. I have a picture also of a band called Al Goodman and his Orchestra. It's not related to Benny Goodman. Al Goodman and his Radio Orchestra. And he had in that band playing saxophone and clarinet Benny Goodman and Artie Shaw. This was like a 25, 30 piece orchestra with strings and all. They played radio shows. Al Goodman and his Orchestra. Then I have a picture of Benny Goodman just playing clarinet with Lenny Hayton's Orchestra. It was a band called the Ipana Troubadours. I don't know if you ever heard that. That was a radio show. And that was a great band. It was a radio broadcast for Ipana toothpaste. And Benny Goodman was the clarinetist in that band, and a wonderful trombone player who became a comedian, like me, Jerry Colanna was the trombone player with that band. That was a wonderful band.

MR: Radio was really important for musicians at that time, wasn't it?

SY: Oh yeah, terrific. I used to listen to Benny Goodman constantly, day and night and night and day, Monk.

MR: Were your parents — how did they feel about your obsession with this?

SY: My father wanted me to own a grocery store in Brooklyn or Coney Island.

MR: Were they supportive of your pursuit of the clarinet?

SY: Yeah sort of.

MR: Yeah? They helped you get one?

SY: Yes my father bought me my first clarinet, believe it or not it was an Albert System clarinet. I still think I have the receipt. We bought it in a pawn shop for $8. An Albert system. Then we bought a Penzer Mueller clarinet. There's an article I gave you, Monk, in 1935 a Penzer Mueller clarinet for $125. That was 1935.

MR: That was a lot of money, wasn't it?

SY: Oh yeah. Today you can buy a clarinet — we're in the year already 2000, unbelievable. A clarinet today costs $2,000. Are the boys outside yet, Tim? Are they downstairs?

TH: They didn't say they saw them anywhere, they were going to take a look for them.

SY: I thought I heard them coughing outside. One of them has a cough.

TH: No there's no one out there.

SY: All right, I'm sorry.

MR: You made a record with Chubby Jackson years ago?

SY: Oh boy, you have a good memory, yeah.

MR: He's a real pistol himself.

SY: Oh yeah.

MR: You two must have been something together.

SY: A very funny guy. Very, very humorous. He has a good attitude and he loves to play and a great player. I don't use that word loosely. To me that word "great" Monk is a superlative. Benny Goodman, great. Louis Armstrong, great. Teddy Wilson, great. Art Tatum, great. Jess Stacy, piano, great. Mel Powell, great. And there were some good players. But the ones I just mentioned, great. Lionel Hampton, great. Harry James, great. Ziggy Elman, great. Toots Mondello, great. Hymie Schertzer, great. Johnny Hodges, great, Coleman Hawkins, the greatest. He recorded with me, I don't know if you know that. I made an album when I was at The Metropole, and Coleman Hawkins was an extra added attraction on my album. He helped sell my album, Monk. His name, believe me. I was very, very indebted to him, willing to record with me.

MR: Was it a ten inch record at that time?

SY: No I think it was a twelve inch record.

MR: Boy I'd like to see something like that.

SY: Yeah I think it was originally made on London Records and then it was sold to Phillips Records. I don't even think I have a copy of it, I'll be honest with you. Coleman Hawkins. He was unbelievable. One of a kind. When he played with Fletcher Henderson's band in the late 20s and 30s, he stood out, as they say, like a sore thumb. That's how powerful he was. He was just — you can't even describe him — how he

overshadowed all the other musicians in that band, and he had some great players. Fletcher Henderson had people like Buster Bailey on clarinet and J.C. Higginbotham and Hilton Jefferson, Coleman Hawkins was something else.

MR: Have you seen any change in your business or your audience in the last few years because of this swing revival?

SY: Yeah, sure. They're bringing back a lot of the big bands. I have been playing, Monk, for the last five or six years, I gave you that article, with a band called Felix and All the Cats. And he has a swing band, a 15 piece swing band, very similar to the Benny Goodman band. We do "Stealing Apples," "Wrapping it Up," "King Porter Stomp," "Bugle Call Rag," "One O'Clock Jump." We play a song with the band [Sol plays]. "You Turn the Tables on me," and then we have an arrangement of a song called "It's Been So Long." [Sol plays].

MR: That was lovely.

SY: That's a song called "It's Been So Long," one of the great ballads Benny Goodman played.

MR: You know the clarinet has such a big range, it's great for that. I mean I love the lower range especially.

SY: Did I play "Peter and the Wolf" for you earlier?

MR: Yes you did.

SY: That's a piece of music I always play whenever I appear anywhere, Monk, and parents come in with their children. That's the first thing I go with. I play that for them and they all love it. They all love "Peter and the Wolf."

MR: My goodness. If you could put together a dream band, from all the people in the past, who would you put on there.

SY: I would have Monk Rowe select them for me.

MR: All right.

SY: You pick them out for me my dear friend.

MR: And you'd corral them and I bet we'd have some great music.

SY: I think so.

MR: Yeah.

SY: I'll let you pick them out.

MR: So you're working seven nights a week.

SY: Play. Correct. I play on Monday nights at a place, an Italian restaurant called LaRavista. That's on Restaurant Row which is West 46th Street between Eighth and Ninth Avenue. I'm there every Monday night. Then on Tuesday and Wednesday and Thursday night I play at a place called the Echo Italia Restaurant, that's on Bleecker Street and Seventh

Avenue. I'm there from 8 to 11 on Tuesday and Wednesday and Thursday nights. Then on Friday night I play at a place in Hackensack, New Jersey. I went there for two weeks, I'm there going on three years, I'm there with a quintet at a place called the Stony Hill Inn. I'm going to give you the brochure of this restaurant. It was built in 1818, that's 180 years ago. Wait until you see it. And I play there every Friday night from 7:30 to 11:30 for dinner, dining, dancing and listening. People love it. I play all these songs every Friday night. [Sol plays].

MR: I can tell you never get tired of it.

SY: No.

MR: I can tell.

SY: That song was played three times in the Benny Goodman movie. I love that song. That was written by my dear friend Eubie Blake. He used to come to see me every birthday he had, for years and years my dear friend. He was a very close friend of mine, Eubie Blake. And when it was his birthday he came to see me, when he was like 98 years old, 99, I think he lived to about 101. And I always played "Memories of You" for him, it actually brought tears to my eyes when I played it for this man who was sitting in the audience, and he wrote the song. And then I'd play a song that he wrote called "I'm Just Wild About Harry," and we would have the audience, I would have the audience sing [sings] "I'm just wild about Eubie," you know that song? [Sol plays]. And then we'd get everybody singing that song. That was Harry Truman's, by the way, that was his favorite song. "I'm Just Wild About Harry."

MR: Yeah. Makes for a good political song.

SY: They played "Memories of You" in the Benny Goodman movie when the picture opened up, and then they played it again at the end of the movie, and they played it again during the Carnegie Hall scene.

MR: Right. And Donna Reed comes in.

SY: Right, Donna Reed walks in. They played it three times.

MR: And he's looking out there.

SY: Yeah. She was a lovely lady by the way, Monk, she was a very, very warm, very fine lady. And we had some good times on the set with Buck Clayton, Ziggy Elman, Harry James. These guys are not around anymore.

MR: Yeah. Well you've certainly brought some good cheer to many, many people over the years.

SY: Thank you.

MR: It's great that you're doing it, still. And I want to thank you for coming today.

SY: I'm not through.

MR: You're not through.

SY: I haven't dismissed you yet. This is only the first part of my life. I've got to tell you about Sal and Arthur. If not for these two lovely gentlemen I wouldn't even be here.

MR: You're going from here — what time do you have to work tonight?

SY: I don't have to start until 8, 8:30. Remember this song? [Sol plays]. This is called the subtone of the clarinet. I once heard Benny Goodman do this on the Camel Caravan show when he played "Poor Butterfly." He did this, Monk. [Sol plays]. He once did that, it broke me up, how he went from the high register to the lower register. His command of the clarinet was unbelievable. Believe me. I mean I heard every clarinetist you could mention in person, Monk. Benny Goodman, Artie Shaw, Jerry Wahl, Tommy Reynolds, Woody Herman, Johnny Mince, Buster Bailey, Peanuts Hucko, Pee Wee Russell. I heard them all. But Benny Goodman was untouchable. And I'll never forget when Artie Shaw was interviewed on the Johnny Carson show one day. And I could imagine he must have had a lot of — you know he gave up the clarinet and then I found out why, because he didn't want to be number two. That was his reason. He knew Benny was number one all the way. And he once, he was on the Johnny Carson show, I remember what he said, he said, "Benny Goodman played the clarinet but I played the music." Just like that he said. Very adamantly and very arrogantly. He says, "oh yeah, Benny Goodman played the clarinet but I played the music." And to crack people, he said it. But that was one of the reasons I found out from the members of his band why he actually gave up the clarinet. He didn't want to be number two. If he felt he couldn't be number one, he just gave it up, he walked off the stand. He walked off, he left his clarinet like that, and he walked right off the stage. Tony Pastor told me this story. Tony Pastor was the one that put his clarinet in the case and that was the end of his career. Can I take a breather for a moment? And I'd like to come back and do some more. Is your men's room — I hope I didn't bore you too much.

[break — cut]

SY: You know Benny Goodman—

TH: Let me get you wired before you start up here.

SY: I hope I'm not boring you with these stories.

MR: Absolutely not. That's why we're here.

SY: Benny Goodman actually never said hello to me. He would always say to me in Jewish, Monk, "you're making a living?" And he would say to me in Jewish "a mach a leiben." M-A-C-H-A I don't know L-E-I-B-E-N I think. But he would always say that. And his brother would say that to me also, Harry, the bass player. A lovely guy. A great guy. Just passed away recently. Harry Goodman was like 95 years old. And he would always say

that to me. "Mach a leiben, mach a leiben." You making a living? You know Benny Goodman came from a very, very poor family. And he came from a family, I think there was like ten children if I'm not mistaken. He was making a living playing his clarinet for his family at the age of maybe 13 years old. He supported his family. His father was a tailor. His father got killed by a truck in Chicago. And Benny Goodman's first job, Tim, was doing an imitation of Ted Lewis. That was his first job, Monk, his first paying job. But that's a true story. He supported his family at that time, at the age of 13 years old. He had a brother called Irving Goodman who played trumpet. I don't know if you remember him. He had another brother who became his manager later on, Freddy Goodman. He had a brother Harry Goodman, a bass player. He had another brother called Joe, then he had another brother that got killed in the Army, a young boy, he was like 19, 20 years old, Jerome, Jerry, got killed. Then he had two sisters whom I knew very well, Ethel Goodman, what a lovely lady, Ethel and Ida. How many children is that all together?

MR: Whew, I lost track.

SY: How many is that? Count with me. Harry, Irving, Freddy, Joe, Jerry, two sisters, Ida and Ethel, that's seven. I don't think I missed any. Irving played trumpet. Freddy played a little trumpet but not that good. He wound up being Benny Goodman's manager. Irving Goodman was with Benny Goodman's band, I'll never forget, at the Hotel New Yorker. Mel Powell was the pianist at that time. And I was there the night they introduced Peggy Lee to sing a song called "Why Don't You Do Right?" And that song took off like gangbusters. Every set after that he went on to play, he had to play that song [scats]. It was like magic that song. Imagine her singing that song every night, every set. That was some band. Irving Goodman was on trumpet. I'm talking as if it was yesterday my dear friend. It was the Hotel New Yorker on 34th Street. It's still there. Irving Goodman and Jimmy Maxwell was on trumpet, and a fellow from Philadelphia called Alec Fila. Do you know that name? Trumpet player. Wonderful trumpet player. F-I-L-A. Alec Fila. And he had in the saxophone section, a fellow called Cliff Strickland who played tenor sax. A wonderful player. Marvelous. Never got any recognition.

MR: Those bands worked awful hard, didn't they, hour wise.

SY: Oh yeah.

MR: Didn't they used to play in between movies, like during the day also, four or five times.

SY: You mean like at the Paramount Theater?

MR: Yeah. The theaters.

SY: Well not Benny Goodman's band. Not Artie Shaw's band. But they had a house band that did that at Radio City Music Hall. You had to be right, between shows the band would play. Radio City had that, you are right, Monk, and the Roxy Theater had house bands,

where these bands would play before the movie or after the movie or between — they would play the shows on the stage. But Benny Goodman never played between. When Benny Goodman played on the Paramount stage, he had acts with them, but he never was there conducting the acts so he'd walk up and let Mel Powell's or somebody's band do it. He used to have the Nicholas Brothers dance for him. Remember those dancers? The two brothers?

MR: They were wild, man.

SY: Beg your pardon?

MR: They were wild.

SY: Oh. Then Benny Goodman at one time, he always used to enjoy playing for dances, he had three fellows called Tip, Tap and Toe. Then he had another group, two black guys that were dancers, they were great, called Stump and Stumpy. You ever hear those names?

MR: Yes.

SY: They were terrific. They were delicious. They were so good. A lot of times Benny Goodman was on the side and somebody else was conducting the band. I don't remember who it was. He picked different guys to conduct the show for them dancers. One time he came out with his clarinet while they were dancing and he played the clarinet for them. It was so good. Do you have a record that Benny Goodman made with Fred Astaire called "Who Cares?" You ever hear that song?

MR: No.

SY: George Gershwin wrote that song. Let me see if I remember. May I please? [Sol plays]. You ever hear that song?

MR: It doesn't sound familiar to me.

SY: George Gershwin wrote that song "Who Cares." And Fred Astaire made a recording of that with Benny Goodman's band on Columbia Records. Great, great record, where he sang, and then he tap danced, and Benny Goodman's sextet at that time with Lionel Hampton and Charlie Christian played the background for him, when he gave him a stop tempo like this Monk [Sol plays]. Then the band would come in. Oh, pick up that record if you can, will ya? And on the other side is another great song that Fred Astaire sang, and he danced, it was called "Just Like Taking Candy From a Baby." Will you remember that or you want to write it down?

MR: I'll remember it.

SY: "Just Like Taking Candy From a Baby." Great record. Great. Fred Astaire singing and dancing on both sides. And it's so exciting, after he tap danced, the band came in. See he was tap dancing to the sextet. They gave him a stop time. Then the band came in like

gangbusters [scats]. Right, the band would come in on the second half [scats]. Get that record please. You'll love it. You'll thank me. Columbia Records. "Who Cares," the other side is "Just Like Taking Candy From a Baby."

MR: Is it a 78 do you think?

SY: At that time.

MR: Okay, well I may have it.

SY: Yeah but they put it on an LP I know. But you — a very exciting record.

MR: Well can I make a musical request to wrap up our interview?

SY: What do you mean wrap up? I haven't dismissed you yet. Didn't you told me this was going to last for at least two, three weeks?

MR: Two, three weeks. Better call downstairs and book the room for a couple more weeks.

SY: Hey, did you give the boys your card? Do you have his card?

MR: Yeah.

SY: Did you hear what Monk Rowe said, call downstairs? Listen I only came here for one purpose. I want you to book me to play for you up in Clinton. Have you brought any musicians?

MR: Yes we have?

SY: Who has appeared there, may I ask?

MR: Well Bob Haggart, Milt Hinton's been up there, Frank Wess.

SY: Well when they came up there, do they come up there with a band or you picked up a local band?

MR: Usually, the fellow that I mentioned, Milt Fillius—

SY: Right. Who knew me from the 40s.

MR: Yes. He puts a group together.

SY: So in other words —

MR: Dave McKenna, Bob Rosengarden.

SY: They were up there already? No kidding.

MR: Yeah.

SY: Oh, so you've had some big names up there already.

MR: Yeah.

SY: And Bob Haggart was the bass player up there at one time?

MR: He came up a couple of times, yeah.

SY: And Milt Hinton was there?

MR: Milt Hinton and Michael Moore.

SY: Oh, wonderful bass players. You know all these guys.

MR: Yeah.

SY: You know who played the bass — speaking about Bob Haggart, Milt Hinton, Michael Moore — you know who played the bass for the soundtrack of "The Benny Goodman Story?" Very few people know.

MR: I'd like to know.

SY: George Duvivier.

MR: Really?

SY: That's right. He was the bass player with the Benny Goodman band on the soundtrack of "The Benny Goodman Story."

MR: But he wasn't in the movie, was he?

SY: No, no.

MR: Right.

SY: The one who was in the movie was Benny Goodman's brother, Harry.

MR: Was that hard to do? Lip sync that stuff on film and make it look real?

SY: Yeah, well I thought, if you watch the movie again, Monk, I thought Steve Allen did a wonderful job with the clarinet. I mean even though I taught him. When he played the clarinet, you remember the symphony part? They took a close-up of his fingers? When he did this part, Monk [Sol plays]. Remember that part?

MR: Yeah. He did a good job.

SY: I thought it was terrific. And then they took shots of him playing all the tunes. He did "Slip Disk" in the movie, remember that one? [Sol plays]. That was the Disk.

MR: Man, you must have a thousand tunes in your head.

SY: How many did you say? How many?

MR: A hundred thousand.

SY: More than that. Did you say a thousand?

MR: I said a thousand.

SY: More than that. Hundreds.

MR: Hundreds of thousands.

SY: I once won a bet, Monk Rowe, in a car going to Atlantic City maybe fifteen years ago, that I couldn't play the clarinet from New York to Atlantic City nonstop. I won a bet that time, a hundred dollar bet. And I played from New York to Atlantic City. I played songs starting off with the letter A, which was "All of Me" I remember as if it was yesterday, and the last song was Z, "Zing Goes the Strings of My Heart." I must have played easy 183 songs. Maybe more, who the hell knows. Just one chorus. I would play like this [Sol plays]. Then I would think of another song with A, "All the Things You Are" [Sol plays]. Then I'd think of another song, A, "Alexander's Ragtime Band" [Sol plays].

MR: "Autumn in New York."

SY: Right. I'm not through yet. When I couldn't think of any more songs with A, then I went to B. All right let me do "Autumn in New York" good song. You know who wrote that, don't you? The same man who wrote "I Can't Get Started." Vernon Duke. Do you know his real name? He was a very dear friend of mine. I did a Broadway show with him called "Sweet By and By." Put that down in your liner notes. The show never came to New York. We played New Haven, Connecticut, we played Philadelphia, we played Boston. The show folded up for some reason, and never came to New York. He did all the music in that show, Vernon Duke. But his name at that time was Vladimir Dukelsky. He came from Russia. And that was the name he used, Tim, on the music. Vladimir Dukelsky. You look him up in the books of songwriters and you'll see Vernon Duke — Vladimir. And he was my very dear friend when I did the show with him. And you know who else was in the show? A girl singer who became a big star later on: Dolores Gray. Do you remember that name?

MR: No.

SY: She was terrific. I don't know what ever happened to her. She was a beautiful gal. She was stately looking. She came out with a negligee to sing a song, it was unbelievable. And then we had a fella in the show, Tim are you listening or are you sleeping? There's a fella in the show who is a pantominist — did I say that name?

MR: Yeah, pantominist.

SY: Gene Sheldon. Do you know that name? Played banjo?

MR: No.

SY: He was terrific. He was terrific. He did all these little things without talking, then he'd come out with a banjo. And then we had a comedian on the show. Does anybody remember from the radio days, a fella called Walter O'Keefe?

MR: That sounds familiar.

SY: Put his name down. He was one of the greats. Walter O'Keefe to me was like a Fred Allen or a Jack Benny. Very funny. In the show a guy comes up to Walter O'Keefe, he says, "I haven't seen you in years." And Walter O'Keefe would say, "it's been longer than that, it's been months." No that sounds funny in the show. And then he says to Walter O'Keefe in the show, he says, "you know, if I woulda hung out with you, if I woulda been with you we woulda made millions." And Walter O'Keefe says, "more than that, we would made thousands." But the way this line went in the show was terrific. And I was the only one who kept laughing in the pit band. We had like a 25 piece orchestra. And I laughed every night at the same routine. Is there a writer of shows called — Alan something? It will come to me. He wrote a book. Okay, I got it, S.J. Perelman. You ever hear that? He wrote the show, the script for the show. S.J. Perelman. A very funny guy.

But why the show never came to New York I'll never know. And Vernon Duke wrote the music. He wrote a song where we used the song — oh thank you sir. You see I understand Indian language. You're terrific, Tim, I like you. He wrote a song that you woulda loved, Monk, called "Low and Lazy" which she sang with her negligee, Dolores Gray. She came out on the corner of the stage with a pin spotlight, is that what you call it?

MR: Yeah.

SY: It was gorgeous. And she sang this sexy song called "Low and Lazy." Then he used the song again at the second part of the show with a beat and he called it "Crisp and Crunchy." The same song with a beat. It was so intelligent what he did. And I don't know, I may still have the music for this show. The name of the show was called "Sweet By and By." It was written by S.J. Perelman, music by Vernon Duke. I wonder if I still have that music. "Crisp and Crunchy," and "Low and Lazy." [Sol plays]. Oh boy, you can't beat George Gershwin. Benny Goodman played with the Philadelphia Symphony for one day, a medley of George Gershwin songs which I tried to play for you right now, Monk, where he started off with the "Rhapsody in Blue." We're going back to the early 1950s, '50, '51. In fact I was working at The Metropole then come to think of it, and I took off. The owner, Ben Harriman, was very upset with me that I took off. I told him, "I want to go see Benny Goodman." He said, "where's he playing?" He thought he was playing in the city where I could hear him and then come back to work. I says, "no, he's playing at the Academy of Music in Philadelphia." He says, "you're going all the way out there to see and hear Ben—" I says, "yes." Anyhow he played this "Rhapsody in Blue" with this Philadelphia Symphony. They did a medley of George Gershwin's songs, like "Someone to Watch Over Me," and "Embraceable You," and then he ended up with "The Man I Love." It was so beautiful it actually brought tears to my eyes. He played it like a classical, like with strings. Like he would play [Sol plays]. And then the last piece he did with the orchestra was [Sol plays]. That's what he did. He went down the low register, it was just beautiful. I'm going back 45 years ago. And I'll never forget that concert, my dear friend. And he did this with the symphony orchestra, a medley of George Gershwin songs. It was gorgeous. I'm sorry if I'm boring you my dear friend.

MR: You're not. I'm going to let my friend Tim get some supper, but could you honor me with a rendition of "Moonglow?" It's always one of my favorites.

SY: It would be my pleasure. That was another song I played going to Atlantic City. I'm serious.

MR: When you got to the M's.

SY: An M. I played a song before that, [Sol plays]. You remember that song? "Make Believe." [Sol plays]. That was from "Roberta." It was a song written by Jerome Kern. That was another song I did. Here's "Moonglow" for you. Thank you. [Sol plays].

MR: Thank you so much.

SY: That's on a new mouthpiece.

MR: That was great.

SY: If you woulda seen what happened to me last night. He said, "Sol? What are you going to do?" "I'll get another mouthpiece."

MR: That same thing happened to me once.

SY: What?

MR: I'm a saxophone player.

SY: Oh no kidding. You never told me that.

MR: Yeah, and I had this nice—

SY: Who'd you study with?

MR: I'm from Rochester.

SY: Yeah, who?

MR: Well I studied with a fella named Roger Eckers who was a local teacher, and then I went to school at Fredonia.

SY: And he taught you saxophone.

MR: Yeah.

SY: Did you go to a clarinet teacher too?

MR: No, never played clarinet much.

SY: Oh, just saxophone.

MR: Clarinet's too hard.

SY: I know, I know. Look at me, would you believe it? What do you think I'm doing here, I'm practicing right now. Could you tell that, Tim? I'm practicing right now?

MR: Never a hint of a squeak either.

SY: Who?

MR: You. I mean all this time. New mouthpiece—

SY: You should have heard me last night with the squeaks. Have you noticed a lot of records that Stan Getz makes, he has little squeaks in them?

MR: Yeah.

SY: But I like that, you know? That shows he has feelings.

MR: It's real.

SY: Real, that's right. You notice? Everybody saying "Hey Sol—" "so what, so what?" What's the name of this piece? Speak about "Moonglow." [Sol plays]. What was the name of that?

MR: "Sunny Side of the Street."

SY: Good. What's the name of this, Monk? Another song with A by the way, speaking about A's [Sol plays]. "Avalon."

MR: Oh yeah.

SY: [Sol plays]. There you go, "Avalon."

MR: Love that moment.

SY: It's unbelievable how I was able to play all these tunes going to Atlan— and as I said when I got exhausted with A I would go to B, I played "Blue Moon" I remember.

MR: "But Beautiful."

SY: No that I didn't play.

[unmiced discussion]